

Digital signatures

Digital signatures can easily be forged and therefore can't be trusted in Outlook because of a certificate chaining issue plaguing Internet Explorer. SSL certificates can be signed by an untrusted intermediary without warning to the end user. Thus, an attacker can sign an untrusted certificate with a trusted, intermediate one. Neither Internet Explorer nor Outlook check basic constraints and the end user is never warned that the certificate chain is questionable. SSLsniff, a tool written to demonstrate the vulnerability, can be used to intercept a third party's SSL session where the victim and attacker are on the same LAN. Microsoft has begun patching the security flaw; you can find the patches for Windows at www.microsoft.com/technet/security/bulletin/MS02-050.asp.

Encrypted=safe

A curious flaw in a PGP's handling of file names could allow an attacker to run a remote Windows machine as Administrator with a malicious, encrypted archive. File names over 200 characters in length cause a buffer overflow, which, if exploited properly, could allow running arbitrary code on the target machine. This code could give the attacker complete control of the PC. A typical attack would involve sending an encrypted archive to a victim via e-mail. The flaw affects PGP Corporate Desktop 7.1.x. for Windows. A patch has been developed by former PGP owner Networks Associates, and is available at www.nai.com/naicommom/download/upgrade/patches/patch-pgphotfix.asp.

Google blocked!

Chinese authorities are feared to have blocked access to the popular search engine, Google (www.google.com). The reason? Google seemingly provides a window to pornography and could also compromise national security. In November last year, the Chinese Government shut down 17,500 Internet cafes for failing to block sites considered subversive or pornographic. Google says it is trying to resolve the problem. Less than a week after

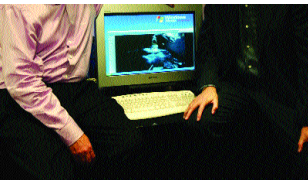
banning Google, even Alta-Vista.com was found to have been blocked in China. These measures come ahead of a Communist Party meeting in November during which the country's leadership is expected to be overhauled. Yahoo! is still accessible though—it is



one of the 130 major Web portals that recently signed a voluntary pledge not to post information that would jeopardise state security and disrupt social stability in China. But there's a humorous twist: someone has set up a Google search mirror—literally! Called elgooG, this beats the Chinese firewall to the outside world. It displays all of the text backwards, requiring you to use a mirror to read it! Check this site at www.all-tooflat.com/geeky/elgoog/.

Released: Windows Media 9

Microsoft has announced the release of the much awaited Windows Media Series 9. It brings advances in usability and performance. Buffering

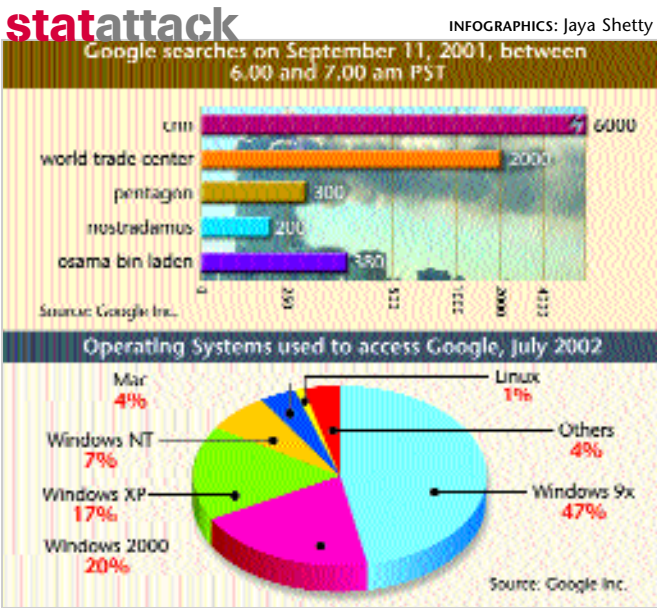


Bill Gates and James Cameron at the launch of Windows Media 9

time on streaming media has been reduced greatly, while audio and video quality has been increased to television quality. It integrates several online content subscription services, including Pressplay, the joint venture between Sony Music Entertainment and Universal Music Group. Microsoft's Digital Rights Management software maintains copyright policies.

Insecure in a Flash

Macromedia has warned that its Flash Player has a vulnerability that could allow attackers to run malicious code on Windows and Unix-based operating systems. More than 90 per cent of PCs are estimated to be capable of playing Flash content. The file-execution vulnerability, discovered by eEye Digital Security, uses a modified header in a Flash movie file to create a buffer overrun, in all versions of Flash Player earlier than 6.0.40.0. The malformed headers can only be created by editing the file with a binary editing tool, and not with the Flash authoring tool. Not only are browsers affected, but also applications capable of reading embedded SWF files, including e-mail and instant messengers. A programmer has also warned that a flaw in the XML functionality of Flash Player 6, and possibly other versions, could allow an attacker to read files on a person's hard drive. This bug has been fixed in newer versions of Flash Player. The latest versions of Flash Players for all software are available at www.macromedia.com.



■ New Kodak cameras less dependant on PCs to share photos ■ MSN Messenger for Mac to be released next year ■ Broadband to hit South Pole by 2009